



MARK J. TERRILL Associated Press

CALIFORNIA has not issued a Flex Alert since 2022, and it has not implemented rotating outages since 2020.

Federal jury acquits rapper Lil Durk

Grammy winner is found not guilty in murder-for-hire trial that drew celebrities.

By BRITTNY MEJIA

A federal jury acquitted Grammy-winning rapper Lil Durk in a murder-for-hire trial that has drawn celebrities, fans and content creators to a downtown Los Angeles courthouse.

The Chicago rapper, whose given name is Durk Banks, was found not guilty of conspiracy, stalking resulting in death and murder for hire. Prosecutors alleged that Banks dispatched hit men to target rapper Quando Rondo, born Tyquian Bowman, for revenge after the death of a close friend.

Instead of killing Bowman, prosecutors said, the hit men fatally shot Bowman's cousin Saviya'a Robinson, 24, in a botched ambush near the bustling Beverly Center on a summer day in 2022.

Deandre Wilson and David Lindsey, who prosecutors alleged was one of the shooters, were on trial alongside Banks. The two men were convicted on the charges of conspiracy to commit stalking, stalking using a dangerous weapon and stalking resulting in death, but were acquitted on the murder-for-hire charges.

Banks, who was in a tan suit and brown tie, appeared nervous ahead of the verdict being read, swaying back and forth and at times swiveling in his chair. As the verdict was read on each of the counts, Banks kept his head down. When the clerk read "not guilty," Banks began wiping away tears.

Despite the verdict, Banks was not released from custody. He is facing a second trial on a racketeering charge that is set for Oct. 5.

More than 60 people had packed into the courtroom. Several more who had been lined up outside were not allowed in. U.S. District Judge Michael W. Fitzgerald warned the gallery to "maintain decorum," stating that the verdicts would be a "moment of either joy or grief."

"Restrain yourselves as the verdicts are read," he said. The packed gallery mostly maintained decorum, letting out a clap when a "not guilty" was read for Banks.

Banks had pleaded not guilty to five separate charges for which he was acquitted: conspiracy to commit stalking, stalking using a dangerous weapon, stalking

[See Lil Durk, A9]

Blackouts avoided in record summer heat

By expanding battery storage, California has increased its electrical grid resilience

By CLARA HARTER

Californians just made it through the hottest August on record without having to endure any rolling power outages.

And, as the Southland continues to sweat its way through record-setting heat and humidity this week, there have been no widespread calls to reduce energy.

In fact, the state has not issued a Flex Alert since 2022, and it has not implemented rotating outages since 2020.

Over the last few years, California has quietly but dramatically increased the resiliency of its electrical grid through a significant expansion in battery energy storage.

These batteries hold on to solar energy captured during the day, so it can be sent to the grid as demand peaks in the evening and morning, when most people are at home running air conditioners and other appliances.

During the August heat wave of 2020, the California Independent System Operator, which manages the flow of elec-

tricity for most of the state, declared a Stage 3 Emergency and hundreds of thousands of households lost power in rolling outages.

At the time, the system had less than 100 megawatts of battery storage available, according to system spokesperson Jayme Ackemann.

Today, it has more than 17,000 megawatts available.

"In about five years, we have vastly increased the amount of battery storage that is available to us," said Ackemann, "and that is great news."

According to Ackemann, the system seeks to add 20,000 to 25,000 megawatts of battery storage capacity by 2045 — the same year it has set a goal of achieving carbon neutrality. That means the state would remove as many carbon emissions from the atmosphere as it emits.

Hitting that goal will require increasing the supply of renewable energy and transitioning

[See Energy, A7]

At one point, the Trump administration imagined a lofty future for the 97-year-old derelict building on the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs' sprawling campus in West Los Angeles.

In a November notice to contractors, the VA described the renovation of the vacant Art Deco structure as a "seed" project for Trump's executive order to create a National Center for Warrior Independence. It would be "reimagined as a vibrant, service-oriented space that honors its historical significance" and "provides meeting spaces and food options to the entire Los Angeles Veteran community to gather."

A bid offering was never put out, however, and now construction is underway instead on what housing experts say is likely the costliest affordable housing that California's notoriously expensive tax credit financing system has yet produced. Using tax-free bond financing, a developer is revamping the upper floor of the two-story building into 24

[See VA, A7]

VA housing with a premium price tag

24 units costing \$1.25 million each included in rehab of L.A. building

By DOUG SMITH



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

BUILDING 13 at the VA's West Los Angeles campus is at the center of a dispute over development.



ANDRES KUDACKI Getty Images

25 YEARS LATER

The nation marked Sept. 11 in New York, above, and beyond. A Times staffer speaks with a friend who was near the towers when they fell. **A5, B2**

Officials' post decried as racist

Homeland Security defends sending image mimicking movie poster that urged Sikh man to self-deport. **NATION, A6**

A jet-lagged flop in Rams opener

Decision to leave late for Australia and a dubious play-call added up to a humbling loss, says Bill Plaschke. **SPORTS, B12**

Weather
Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 86/69. **B8**



Architect of billionaire tax faces accusations

Union leader tried to 'extort' support from others, report says. He denies the allegations.

By TARYN LUNA

SACRAMENTO — SEIU United Healthcare Workers West President Dave Regan allegedly tried to "extort" an SEIU state council endorsement of the billionaire tax ballot measure from other California union leaders, according to an investigation commissioned by Service Employees International Union.

The investigation and a second inquiry conducted on behalf of SEIU California found that Regan allegedly threatened and intimidated women who worked for the state council, and in one instance, physically assaulted a former executive director of the labor organization.

Regan, in an interview with The Times, denied the allegations that he attempted to extort from union officials. He also denied assaulting the executive director and said he did not threaten female labor leaders. He repeated a counterclaim he made to the

union: The allegations against him are retaliation for his advocacy for Proposition 40, the proposed wealth tax that will be on the Nov. 3 ballot.

"They are internally contradictory, they are fundamentally biased, and maybe most importantly, they are politically motivated," Regan said about the probes.

The law firm hired by the national union investigated Regan's claim of retaliation but found the allegation could not be substantiated.

David Huerta, the president of SEIU United Service Workers West, and three other labor leaders filed a rare formal union charge against Regan in February.

The national union of SEIU has ultimate authority to resolve charges filed under its constitution and hired the New York labor law firm Cohen, Weiss and Simon to independently investigate the claims. The firm interviewed 18 current and former SEIU leaders and others in the California labor movement over nearly three months, according to its report.

The law firm's report, reviewed by The Times, supported Huerta's claim that on Dec. 3 Regan suggested

[See SEIU, A9]

Could rogue AI really kill us all?

Fears rise as industry insiders reveal belief that humans could be wiped out in a decade.

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

Artificial intelligence anxiety reached new highs this week as industry leaders highlighted growing concerns that humans could lose control of the increasingly potent technology.

A researcher at trailblazing firm Anthropic resigned this week, issuing a dire warning: Top AI companies are gambling with humanity's future.

Jacob Coxon cautioned that both OpenAI and Anthropic are recklessly racing to build AI systems they cannot fully control or comprehend.

"These will soon be superhuman systems that can

hack anything, revolutionize any field overnight, and acquire real power and resources," Coxon wrote on social media. He said Anthropic and OpenAI, where he also has worked, are downplaying the potential power of what they are building.

"The people building AI earnestly believe that it could kill us all by the end of the decade," he wrote.

Evan Hubinger, whose job at Anthropic is to ensure AI systems align with human values, echoed his concerns.

"We really do earnestly believe AI could kill all humans!" he wrote on X, estimating that there is a greater than 10% chance of human extinction from AI within the next decade. He added: "I believe Anthropic is trying its best, but we do not yet have a plan to solve alignment for superintelligence and are not clearly on track

[See AI, A12]

WAKE-UP CALL: Viral warning may be the alarm that saves us, Anita Chabria writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

President is unfazed: 'It's going to be fine'

Lawmakers, scientists worry he doesn't grasp the stakes as calls for AI regulation grow.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — President Trump is brushing aside growing concern among leading scientists and bipartisan lawmakers that artificial intelligence could soon pose an existential threat to humanity, fueling anxiety in Washington and Silicon Valley that the president may not fully grasp the urgency of the threat.

Alarm mounted throughout the summer as researchers at leading AI labs, including Anthropic, OpenAI and Google, found the pace of development far outstripping their expectations — and observed troubling behaviors that hinted at more serious risks ahead.

But an online warning Tuesday from an Anthropic researcher who resigned in protest of its ongoing work has generated viral attention this week, prompting questions to Trump, who dismissed the concerns out of hand.

"It's going to be fine," he told one reporter. "We'll always have something to stop them. We'll have a little gear. Boom."

In another exchange, traveling with reporters Thursday night, the president said he had no concerns with the breakneck pace of AI progress.

"No, I don't have any," he said. "I have concerns that if we don't win in AI, we're going to be put in a very bad position."

A senior industry source told The Times that leading AI Companies are focused less on convincing the president of the dangers ahead than on working with lawmakers on potential regula-

[See Regulation, A7]